importance of this showdown can be gauged by how Tandon framed it on his way to Nasik. Speaking to reporters at Jhansi railway station, Tandon declared that he and other party leaders were 'going to Nasik to decide finally the question of *whether the Congress must live or die* at this stage [emphasis added]'. The fact that this statement was uttered in the presence of another Hindu traditionalist, UP Chief Minister Govind Ballabh Pant, underscored the nature of the rift.[40] Another UP Congress leader put this in context, saying that 'contradictions within the Congress, artificially suppressed so far', between the forces of 'reaction and progress' were now coming to a head.[41] So important was this session that the US embassy in Delhi sent an observer to attend it.[42]

As both Nehru and Tandon headed to Nasik for a show of strength, newspapers openly wrote about the possibility of a 'split' in the Congress, which in turn could 'possibly result in another exodus of Muslims from India and accelerate the migration of Hindus from Pakistan'.[43] Interestingly, Tandon seems to have met both Nehru and Patel after his election to have a 'free and frank exchange of views' on Nehru's policies. Old friends from UP, now divided by ideas, Nehru and Tandon had agreed to continue working together. Yet, the divide was so deep that the possibility of Nehru resigning from the government and the Congress Working Committee was discussed in these meetings. The prime minister had been persuaded not to do so for the moment, but a newspaper reported that he had 'not made up his mind' on resigning.[44]

Amidst a heavy downpour that practically turned the Nasik meeting into a swamp, Nehru took the stage. He went straight for the jugular: a threat to resign. 'I am Prime Minister,' he told the Congress's delegates, 'because you have chosen me.' As he put it:[45]

If you want me as Prime Minister you have to follow my lead unequivocally. If you do not want me as Prime Minister, you tell me so and I shall go. I will not hesitate. I will not argue. I will go out and fight for the ideals of the Congress as I have done all these years.